

Shamet Off The Bench

2023-24 Season Preview

Finn Irving

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Western Conference

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- 2. Denver Nuggets**
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- 6. Oklahoma City Thunder**
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East

#1 - Milwaukee Bucks

General Thoughts – This is a team who went out with an extremely disappointing first-round exit to the Heat last year. They bring back the entirety of their championship core, with Giannis, Middleton, Brook Lopez, and Jrue Holiday. I really like the signing of Malik Beasley. I think he is a winning player who can contribute to this team, whether it is as a starting SG, or as the first guard off the bench. There are rumors starting to swirl around this team regarding Giannis leaving... but I feel those are mostly curated by the media. I still think this team is really good and can certainly contend for another title this year. It will require Khris Middleton to be healthy, as losing him in the playoffs certainly exposes the obvious holes in Giannis' game. If Giannis' could ever add a jumper to his game, it would revolutionize this team, but at this point I don't see that happening.

Edited Post-Lillard trade

I respect the Bucks for going out and making the trade for Damian Lillard. I think it will severely hurt them defensively... as Jrue Holiday is one of the premier defenders in the league. But they are in a win-now position, and I think this move is worth it. Guarding this team is going to be an absolute nightmare, they have a ridiculous number of weapons. I see them as the best team in the East now, and perhaps the favorites to win the title.

Additions – Malik Beasley, Robin Lopez, Damian Lillard

Losses – Jevon Carter, Joe Ingles, Wesley Matthews, Jrue Holiday, Grayson Allen

#2 - Boston Celtics

General Thoughts – Resigning Jaylen Brown to a supermax confirms that the Celtics feel they can win a title with the duo of Jayson Tatum and Jaylen Brown. I agree with this. I feel as though they are knocking on the door. But both have weaknesses in their game. Tatum has wildly inconsistent performances from one game to the next, while Brown cannot dribble, especially not with his left hand. They went out and got Kristaps Porzingis who, when healthy, is quite effective. However, he has been injured every year since his rookie year. Losing Marcus Smart and Grant Williams will ultimately hurt this team a lot I believe. These were their "dawgs" ... the ones who I could not STAND watching play, because they did all those little scrappy things which are so important. Without them, they really do not have a player who plays in such a way. I do still think they will finish as a top seed in the East, but to win a title will require superstar level performances from Tatum and Brown, along with a step-up in performance from the likes of Derrick White and Robert Williams III.

Edited Post-Holiday trade

Well, the Celtics have made it clear. They need to win now, and they don't think they could have done it with the team which they have had the previous few seasons. Jrue Holiday is a winner, and is instantly the best defender on this team. A healthy quartet of Holiday, Brown, Tatum and Porzingis is disgusting... but there is a large emphasis on the healthy part. They have decimated the depth which once was

arguably the best in the league. I am not sure if they have gotten better by these two additions, but they are going for it, and I respect that.

Additions – Kristaps Porzingis, Dalano Banton, Oshae Brissett, Jrue Holiday

Losses – Marcus Smart, Grant Williams, Danilo Gallinari, Robert Williams, Malcolm Brogdon

#3 - New York Knicks

General Thoughts – Everyone already knows how I feel about these New York Knicks. I love ‘em. I think they have such a high upside. Getting rid of Obi Toppin and bringing in Donte DiVincenzo gets rid of their worst player, while bringing in a proven winner, who has played at Villanova with Jalen Brunson and Josh Hart. They bring back their whole team from last year. Improved shot selection would be crucial for this team, as the duo of Julius Randle and RJ Barrett are chucking up 13 combined threes a game. Brunson is the top dog on this team, and those two need to be aware of that. Defensively, with Hart, Quentin Grimes, and Big Meech to protect the rim, this team is lethal. Efficiency is the only thing holding this team back currently. They certainly have the upside to win the East.

Additions – Donte DiVincenzo

Losses – Derrick Rose, Obi Toppin

#4 - Cleveland Cavaliers

General Thoughts – I view the Cavs as a real sleeper team for this year. I am not a huge believer in Donovan Mitchell, but I think they have built a really solid team around him. Darius Garland is a stud Point Guard, and the big combo of Evan Mobley and Jarrett Allen is a deadly shot-blocking interior. Free agent signings Max Strus and Georges Niang should provide much needed shooting for this team. Offense was a real struggle at times last year, and this should help mend that somewhat. I think Caris LeVert and Isaac Okoro provide athleticism and scoring ability off the bench, and are great pieces for a winning team. This team could be anywhere from a first-round exit to a title contender. I think their performance will be heavily dependent on the continued growth of Garland and Mobley.

Additions – Max Strus, Georges Niang, Ty Jerome

Losses – Danny Green, Robin Lopez, Cedi Osman

#5 - Miami Heat

General Thoughts – It is so easy to underestimate the Heat... but it is in large part due to the fact that, on paper, they simply do not impress. Yet year in and year out, the duo of Pat Riley and Erik Spoelstra continue to churn out championship-caliber teams. Their core of Jimmy Butler, Tyler Herro and Bam Adebayo returns. I think the losses of Gabe Vincent and Max Strus will hurt them. The only true PG on their roster is old and fat Kyle Lowry (Herro listed as starting PG currently). They did go out and sign Josh

Richardson, but I am not a fan of his. No matter how their team looks, I am sure they will find ways to be successful... and a team that nobody wants to square off against in the playoffs.

Additions – Josh Richardson, Thomas Bryant

Losses – Gabe Vincent, Max Strus, Victor Oladipo, Cody Zeller, Omer Yurtseven

#6 - Philadelphia 76ers

General Thoughts – I am not, and have never been a fan of the Sixers. I think they will still have a decent seed going into the playoffs, simply because they have players who can score. However, I view them as nothing more than a first-round exit. The duo of James Harden and Joel Embiid is the whiniest, most selfish, losing duo in the league. Throw in some other real painful players to watch like Tobias Harris, Patrick Beverley, and PJ Tucker, and you have a team who nobody but 76ers fans would enjoy. I do think Tyrese Maxey is a very good player, the next backbone of this franchise. I think their depth is lacking, and they simply do not have the punch which they have possessed in years past.

Additions – Patrick Beverley, Mo Bamba, Danny Green

Losses – Jalen McDaniels, Shake Milton, Georges Niang, Dewayne Dedmon

#7 - Indiana Pacers

General Thoughts – I actually really like the build of this Pacers team. I feel they have a lot of upside. Tyrese Haliburton is a certified stud. They signed him to a huge contract... meaning he is their guy... the player they will build their team around. Second-year Benn Mathurin had a strong rookie campaign and will look to build upon it this year. Jarace Walker was an animal in college, and I expect him to have a great rookie season. There have been rumors of them trading Buddy Hield, which would be a real mistake. He led the league in 3pm last season and is one of the best shooters in the entire league. Myles Turner is a great player when he stays healthy, but he seems to find himself injured every year. With a strong bench as well, I feel as though this team has the potential to have a real good season this year... pushing the 5-7 seed area, but it will require things to go correctly.

Additions – Bruce Brown, Obi Toppin

Losses - Oshae Brissett, Chris Duarte

#8 - Brooklyn Nets

General Thoughts – The Nets are one of the most difficult teams for me to get a read on. Mikal Bridges emerged as their “star” down the stretch last year. It will be interesting to see if he can maintain that status. Players such as Spencer Dinwiddie, Cam Johnson, and Nic Claxton are all young players with a lot of upside. I am just not sure how they will all work together over the course of the year. This team looks sort of like a fantasy draft in NBA2K. The talent is there, but it feels a bit like a mosh of random players. With all the draft picks they accrued from shopping Kyrie Irving and Kevin Durant, they have a bright

future ahead of them... but I do not think this year will wield much more than mediocrity and a first-round exit in the playoffs.

Additions – Lonnie Walker IV, Dennis Smith Jr

Losses – Seth Curry, Yuta Watanabe, Patty Mills, Joe Harris

#9 - Washington Wizards

General Thoughts – Here they are. The reason I am doing these rankings. The Washington Wizards. I uttered those famous words – “Shamet off the Bench” ... and I will stand by them all year long. This team will make the playoffs. I firmly believe it. Jordan Poole is certainly a flawed player, but I think he will thrive in an environment where he can shoot it as frequently as he pleases. He was hamstrung a bit in the Golden State offense, where he was not top dog, or even second top dog. While he may be inefficient at times, he can light it up, and I predict he will score nearly 30 ppg. Kuzma is another player who can score the ball in great volumes. I love their addition of Tyus Jones. I think he has been the best backup PG in the league for several years. Here, he will step into a starting spot, and I believe he will thrive. He has led the league in assist/turnover ratio for 5 consecutive seasons. Other players such as Corey Kispert, Daniel Gafford, Deni Avdija, and Delon Wright will all be serviceable role players for the team. And of course, lastly, you have the one and only Landry Shamet. That is the secret weapon of this Wizards team. His services will be unparalleled. He has a career winning percentage of .649 and will bring his winning ways to Washington and change the culture. Mark my words... this team will make the playoffs.

Additions – Danilo Gallinari, Tyus Jones, Jordan Poole, LANDRY SHAMET

Losses – Kristaps Porzingis, Monte Morris

#10 - Atlanta Hawks

General Thoughts – This team is a tough team to read. On paper, they have a lot of weapons. But it seems as though every year, they are unable to put it together. They have moved on from John Collins and shifting their focus to the young Onyeka Okongwu. There has been rumored dissension between Trae Young and the coaching staff there, which could lead to an unsettled feeling throughout the franchise. I do think the duo of Trae Young and Dejounte Murray could be very effective. They present a real diverse skillset in the backcourt. Stretch forwards like De’Andre Hunter and Saddiq Bey provide a lot of versatility, while Bogdan Bogdanovic is a lights-out shooter off the bench (40.6% 3pt). I think the talent is there... but until they put it all together, I’m not a believer. I think another play-in game is destined for this team.

Additions – Patty Mills

Losses – John Collins

#11 - Chicago Bulls

General Thoughts – This is a team with no real direction. They do not have any real young stars, but yet are miring in the play-in game mix every year. The trio of LaVine, DeRozan and Vucevic seems solid, but has produced no results at all. They have a real clog of guards off the bench, with Jevon Carter, Ayo Dosunmu and Coby White... and nothing to do with them. I do not see this team finishing any higher than the 9/10 seed area, and would not be surprised at all to see them miss the playoffs entirely. They need to decide quickly whether they want to tank or not, because currently they are very much so stuck in the middle.

Additions – Jevon Carter, Torrey Craig

Losses – Patrick Beverley

#12 - Toronto Raptors

General Thoughts – I'll keep it simple; I think the Raptors stink. Pascal Siakam is their "star", but I really do not believe he is that good at all. Scottie Barnes and OG Anunoby make for a strong defensive tandem, with great length. I feel these are their best two pieces... but neither is an excellent offensive option. I am a fan of Gradey Dick; I think he will provide some much-needed offense to this team. I would say he is a dark horse candidate for Rookie of the Year. They will miss Fred VanVleet... despite the fact that I do not have a high opinion of him, he was still one of their primary scorers and everyday Point Guard. Despite his leading Team Germany to the FIBA World Cup gold medal, I do not anticipate Dennis Schroder being able to fill that role.

Additions – Jalen McDaniels, Dennis Schroder

Losses – Fred VanVleet, Dalano Banton

#13 – Detroit Pistons

General Thoughts – For once, I feel like the Pistons have a sense of direction with their team. They are starting to develop a nice young core with the likes of Cade Cunningham, Jaden Ivey and Jalen Duren. They also made some nice pickups in the offseason, in Joe Harris and Monte Morris. Harris gives them the weapon of having a deadeye shooter off the bench, while Morris is a perfect backup Point Guard. Bojan Bogdanovic is a consistent scorer, but no real part of their long-term plans. I was disappointed in their draft choice though. I think the Thompson twins are both going to be terrible. I do not see this team making a playoff push yet, but for once, I feel as though the Pistons are trending in the right direction.

Additions – Joe Harris, Monte Morris

Losses – Cory Joseph

#14 – Orlando Magic

General Thoughts – Talk about a terrible draft. Anthony Black and Jett Howard?? I don't like either of these picks one bit. I have no clue about the direction of this franchise. I feel as though they have been hanging around the bottom of the standings for years now. They do have a franchise player in Paolo Banchero, I think he proved last year he is the real deal. But they have limited pieces around him. Markelle Fultz is starting to finally come into his own as a player, and show glimpses of why he was once the #1 overall pick. Franz Wagner has also shown that he can be a solid NBA 3-man. Aside from this however, it is struggle city. They essentially had no movement in the offseason, aside from signing Joe Ingles. Another season in the basement is what's on the forecast for the Orlando Magic.

Additions – Joe Ingles

Losses – Bol Bol

#15 - Charlotte Hornets

General Thoughts – Yuck. This may be the worst team in the entire league. I am not a believer in Brandon Miller, I think they will regret drafting him over Scoot Henderson in retrospect. They have all sorts of off-court drama with Miles Bridges returning from jail, and Kai Jones going absolutely off-the-chain on social media. While LaMelo Ball has actually put-up good numbers this far in his career, I just have no faith that any member of the Ball circus could truly lead a team to success. The only player on this team I actually like is Mark Williams. With his 7'1" height and 7'7" wingspan, he is an absolute menace in the paint defensively. He was amazing at Duke, especially on their run to the Final Four. I think he has the brightest future of anyone on this team. P.J. Washington is another solid player, but he is no more than an above average role player. There's no way this team is good this year, or even close to .500. If I was a betting man, I would put my money on the Hornets to have the worst record in the NBA this season.

Additions – Frank Ntilikina

Losses – Dennis Smith Jr

West

#1 - Phoenix Suns

General Thoughts – This team has an absolute influx of talent. Whether it will work out is another question. As for me, I'm a believer. I think the trio of Beal, Booker and Durant is virtually impossible to stop. In order for this team to reach their full potential, Kevin Durant has to be healthy and play a full year. I like the Ayton trade. I think Nurkic can do everything that Ayton could, for less money. They acquired a ridiculous amount of depth this offseason. Eric Gordon (42.3%), Grayson Allen (39.9%), Yuta Watanabe (44.4%), and returner Damian Lee (44.5%) are all great 3-point shooters off the bench. Josh Okogie (6'4" with a 7'0" wingspan), Nasir Little (6'6" with a 7'1" wingspan) and Keita Bates-Diop (6'7" with a 7'4" wingspan) bring insane length and defensive versatility to this team. I think this team has all the pieces to win a championship, and would currently be my pick. The only question is whether all these new pieces, alongside new coach Frank Vogel, can find the continuity necessary to bring it home.

Additions – Bradley Beal, Keita Bates-Diop, Drew Eubanks, Eric Gordon, Yuta Watanabe, Grayson Allen, Jusuf Nurkic, Nasir Little

Losses – Torrey Craig, Jock Landale, Cameron Payne, Chris Paul, Landry Shamet, DeAndre Ayton

#2 - Denver Nuggets

General Thoughts – The reigning champs bring back virtually the exact roster as last year. The only main player they lost was Bruce Brown, and he is easily replaceable. They did not really bring anyone in either. The Nuggets are operating under the “if it ain’t broke, don’t fix it” method. The duo of Jokic and Murray will be coming back in full force, ready to defend their title. The vast improvement of players like Aaron Gordon and Michael Porter Jr. played a huge role in their run to the championship, and they will need to be able to maintain that level in order for them to contend again. This team can certainly win another title. Their continuity is unmatched by any other team in the league. It is very difficult to win back-to-back titles in any sport... but it does happen in the NBA more frequently than other leagues.

Additions – Justin Holiday, Jay Huff

Losses – Bruce Brown, Thomas Bryant, Jeff Green

#3 - Memphis Grizzlies

General Thoughts – Despite all the wildness surrounding Ja “Fake Tough Guy” Morant, this is still a really good team. Morant will be out for the first 25 games of the season, while serving his suspension. Marcus Smart is a perfect addition to this team, and will fit right in. Players such as Desmond Bane and Jaren Jackson Jr. will have to carry the load while Morant is out, but this is a team who has always performed very well when Morant does not play. Brandon Clarke, who I believe is a real X-factor for this team will not be healthy for the start of the season, as he is still recovering from an Achilles injury he suffered last season. Luke Kennard was hurt for much of last year, but he is a real weapon when healthy. I really like Tyus Jones and think losing him will hurt, but they covered that pretty well with Smart. The loss of Dillon Brooks is addition by subtraction... and will open up roughly 15 shots a game for others. I think this team is not one of the leading candidates to win the title, but I do think they have the talent and capability to if things were to fall into place. I’d put them as one of the fringe contenders.

Additions – Derrick Rose, Josh Christopher, Marcus Smart

Losses – Dillon Brooks, Tyus Jones

#4 - Sacramento Kings

General Thoughts – The Kings are another team who brings back their entire roster from last year. They fell just short to Golden State in the first-round last year, but it took everything Steph and the gang had to take them down. Now, a return to the playoffs is in the cards and this team will look to build upon last year’s success. De’Aaron Fox is a stud, and Domantas Sabonis is also a really good center. The guard/big duos have been experiencing a lot of success in the league recently (A la Jokic/Murray) and they could be

the next big thing. Keegan Murray had a strong rookie season (41.4 3pt %) and has the potential to take a leap in his sophomore campaign. Other players like Harrison Barnes and Kevin Huerter are very consistent role players, while Malik Monk provides some dynamite off the bench. They acquired reigning EuroLeague MVP Sasha Vezenkov as well. I have no clue if he will be good or not. All I know is he is a Power Forward. But he could be a potential big add to their roster. I do not think this team has a shot at the title, but they will look to break through in the playoffs this year, winning at least one series.

Additions – Sasha Vezenkov (EuroLeague MVP), JaVale McGee, Chris Duarte

Losses – Richaun Holmes

#5 - Los Angeles Lakers

General Thoughts – What a flurry of moves this team made in the offseason! I think some are good and some are bad. Gabe Vincent is a real winning player and should be a great addition to this team. Taurean Prince is a solid role player, while Jaxson Hayes has tremendous potential. I think the Christian Wood/Cam Reddish signings are not good. They are both one-sided ball-hogs who will not be able to contribute much to this team. This team really clicked down the stretch last season, shocking everyone by making it to the WCF. I think they have similar potential this year. A lot will rest on the hands of aging LeBron and the weakest player on planet Earth - Anthony Davis, being able to stay healthy this year. I do not have much faith in that happening. Players like Austin Reaves, Jarred Vanderbilt and Rui Hachimura were extremely effective in the playoffs last year... and I will be interested to see if they can continue that success this season. There will be a lot of hype surrounding this team obviously, as it is the Lakers. And while I do believe they will be a fair deal better than last year... I do not view them as contenders for a title. A first or second round exit would be my prediction for this team.

Additions – Gabe Vincent, Christian Wood, Cam Reddish, Taurean Prince, Jaxson Hayes

Losses – Mo Bamba, Malik Beasley, Dennis Schroder, Lonnie Walker IV

#6 - Oklahoma City Thunder

General Thoughts – This is my favorite young team in the league, and perhaps the team I believe has the greatest potential. SGA has proven himself to be a true star in this league and one of the best pure scorers. Josh Giddey is a great compliment to him, and a triple-double threat every night. I am eager to watch Chet Holmgren play, as I was a huge fan when he was at Gonzaga. I think he has the potential to be awesome. Players like Lu Dort (The Dorture Chamber) and Jalen Williams are some dawgs. By dawgs I mean they are tough as nails and are really good defenders. Jalen Williams had a great rookie season and if he can replicate that, or build off of it this year it would be huge for this team. Isaiah Joe was a 41% 3pt shooter off the bench last year. I do not like their draft pick of Cason Wallace... but he is nothing but a backup guard for the team. I think this team has the ability to take a huge leap this year... and I know I will be heavily rooting for them to do so.

Additions – Victor Oladipo, Davis Bertans

Losses – Dario Saric

#7 - Golden State Warriors

General Thoughts – Golden State is one of the toughest teams for me to evaluate. I want them to be good, and I feel as though there is a fleeting chance they are. But deep down I feel as though the reign is officially over. Steph is still just as good as ever... but the surrounding pieces are fading. Klay is no longer the player he once was, and Draymond is so concerned with arguing for the entirety of each game it detracts from his ability. They made the Chris Paul trade in the efforts of winning one last ring. I respect the move... I do feel they will miss Jordan Poole in the future. It is hard to guess how a Paul/Curry backcourt will work. I think Paul's passing ability with their shooting could work well. This team is old, and this team has no height. Kevon Looney and Draymond are their centers, at 6'6" and 6'9". They will struggle to contain any height, which was ultimately their downfall last year, as they could not stop Anthony Davis. I think they really need to let the young guys play more, like Jonathan Kuminga and Moses Moody. Both have a ton of potential but have been hamstrung their whole careers by being stuck behind veterans. Eventually Steve Kerr is going to have to let them loose. I think there is a very slim chance of this team competing for a title if everything goes right, but I do not see it realistically happening.

Additions – Chris Paul, Cory Joseph, Dario Saric

Losses – Donte DiVincenzo, Jordan Poole, Ty Jerome

#8 - New Orleans Pelicans

General Thoughts – On paper, this team looks magnificent. They have incredible length, athleticism, and scoring ability. Yet, they have yet to do so. Their two best players, Zion Williamson and Brandon Ingram can never stay healthy, playing 29 and 45 games last year. They do not really have a PG on their roster. CJ McCollum is their projected point guard, but he is much more of a SG. A starting 5 of McCollum/Ingram/Herb Jones/Zion/Valanciunas with Trey Murphy (48/40/90 last year) as a 6th man looks as good as any team in the league. Perhaps this will be the year they breakout... I'm not sure. But I have thought that they were a breakout candidate for several years now and it has yet to happen. I will remain skeptical of this team until they prove me wrong! I predict another play-in game for the Pelicans.

Additions – Cody Zeller

Losses – Jaxon Hayes, Josh Richardson

#9 - Minnesota Timberwolves

General Thoughts – The Timberwolves are the LA Angels of the NBA. They are so poorly run. The Rudy Gobert trade has got to be one of the worst trades of all time. Anthony Edwards is blossoming into one of the best players in the league... and is quite exciting to watch. However, he is stuck in this dumpster-fire of an organization. They would benefit greatly from a full, healthy season of Karl-Anthony Towns, as

he only played 29 games last season. Jaden McDaniels was 1 of only 6 players last year to shoot 40% from three while averaging more than 0.8 blocks and 0.8 steals a game last year... and is a premier defender. This team has potential to be good, and I wouldn't be overly surprised if they compiled a playoff-caliber season. In order for this to happen, Edwards needs to take another step forward, while their tandem of Towns/Gobert excels.

Additions – Shake Milton

Losses – Taurean Prince

#10 - Los Angeles Clippers

General Thoughts – What an old, boring team! Full of veterans who load manage all the time, I am not a fan of the Clippers at all. Kawhi and Paul George theoretically form a formidable duo, but they are never on the court together (38 games played together last year). They did not do much over the offseason at all, besides adding Kenyon Martin Jr, an athletic wing who can play several positions. Russell Westbrook is over the hill, although he did fulfill a solid role for their team last year. Ivica Zubac is a solid big, but there is little dynamism in his game. I see little to no upside in this team. I would expect a season within a few games of .500.

Additions – Kenyon Martin Jr

Losses – Eric Gordon

#11 - Portland Trail Blazers

General Thoughts – Wow! From the time I started working on this project until now, the Blazers have made two huge trades! I think they got a great haul from both trades, and now have a new core to build around. I do not think they will have to spend much time rebuilding, as they have solid pieces on their team right now. Anfernee Simons, Shaedon Sharpe, and Jerami Grant return from last year, who are all good players, Simons and Grant more as scorers, and Sharpe as a versatile wing (with maybe the best dunk package in the game). DeAndre Ayton and Robert Williams are both proven big men, both still young at 25 years old. I am a big Scoot Henderson fan. I think he is electric to watch, and will have one of the best rookie years of anyone this year. This team could contend for the playoffs right away. I do not see them making it this year, with so many new players in the mix, but I do not think it will take long. I am a fan of the new look Portland Trail Blazers.

Additions – DeAndre Ayton, Robert Williams, Malcolm Brogdon

Losses – Drew Eubanks, Cam Reddish, Damian Lillard, Nasir Little, Jusuf Nurkic

#12 - Utah Jazz

General Thoughts – The Jazz are one of the more patchwork teams in the league. They bring back their whole team from last year, while also snagging John Collins in a trade with the Hawks for virtually nothing. Lauri Markkanen had a massive breakout year last year... it will be interesting to see if he can replicate it again this year. I do really like their theory of playing massive lineups, as 7'0" Markkanen is currently lined up as the Small Forward! Walker Kessler had a great rookie season last year, and I anticipate him taking a large step forward in his sophomore campaign. Their backcourt of Sexton and Clarkson is not ideal. Clarkson is a chucker and Sexton cannot stay healthy. I think this team has some good pieces, but I am not a fan of how it all fits together. I think they can fight for a playoff spot, but I do not see them obtaining one.

Additions – Omer Yurtseven, John Collins

Losses – Rudy Gay

#13 - Dallas Mavericks

General Thoughts – Perhaps one of my least favorite teams in the league, led by one of my least favorite players in the league, whiny little Luka Doncic. I do not think he is a winning player at all. The more I look at this team, the less I like them. They made a blockbuster trade for Kyrie last year, only to then falter down the stretch and miss the playoffs completely. Their offseason moves were rather transparent. The trio of Seth Curry, Grant Williams and Richaun Holmes is rather equitable to those they lost (Christian Wood/Reggie Bullock/Davis Bertans). I will be interested to see how rookie Dereck Lively II performs for this team. He is their current projected starting center. Although he did not put-up gaudy numbers at Duke, he has the perfect build for an NBA big, and is a tremendous shot blocker. This team has no depth, and will be incredibly dependent on Luka and Kyrie to carry them. I do not think they have it in them... and will most likely end up missing the playoffs yet again.

Additions – Seth Curry, Grant Williams, Richaun Holmes

Losses – Christian Wood, Reggie Bullock, Davis Bertans, JaVale McGee

#14 - San Antonio Spurs

General Thoughts – Everyone's eyes will be on the Spurs this year to watch the debut of Victor Wembanyama, and rightfully so! He is one of the most exciting prospects to ever enter the league. I hope he is every bit as good as advertised. I think being coached by Gregg Popovich will allow him to reach his full potential. However, the rest of this roster is still rather terrible. I do not see this team achieving too much success this season, unless Wemby is otherworldly. Popovich will have them playing **fundamentally sound** Spurs basketball... but the talent simply is not there. Devin Vassell is probably their next best player, as a wing that can score the ball fairly well. Keldon Johnson may have scored a lot of points last year, but is just a chucker, and has no shot of being a key piece of a winning team. Other main players such as Tre Jones, Jeremy Sochan and Zach Collins are just very below average. The Spurs are still rebuilding, but they now have the key piece they need, and being the excellently-run organization that they are, I trust they will not screw it up.

Additions – Reggie Bullock, Cedi Osman

Losses – Keita Bates-Diop

#15 - Houston Rockets

General Thoughts – I just absolutely hate the build of this team. As if they did not have enough chuckers, they brought in the two players with the worst FG% in the league last year, in Fred VanVleet (39.3%) and Dillon Brooks (39.6%). Jabari Smith Jr. was so atrocious last season they had him play in the Summer League again. Jalen Green is a massive ball hog who shoots the ball 18 times a game. I am not a fan of the Thompson twin, as he cannot score at all. Their other main pick, Cam Whitmore, I do not know much about, as I did not watch him much in college since Villanova was so bad last year. I do like a couple of their pieces, like Alp Sengun and Tari Eason. I think both are good young players who they could potentially build around. However, there is simply too much baggage on this roster for them to be able to do so. Perhaps new coach Ime Udoka can find a way to turn this roster around, but he will have his work cut out for him. I think they will undoubtedly finish last in the stacked West.

Additions – Fred VanVleet, Dillon Brooks, Jeff Green, Jock Landale

Losses – Kenyon Martin Jr., Josh Christopher